Forum:	Security Council (SC)
Issue:	Maintaining peace and security in the Strait of Hormuz during periods of heightened tensions
Author:	Sophia Albani
Position:	Deputy President

Personal Introduction

Dear delegates,

My name is Sophia Albani, and I have the honour of serving as a Deputy President of the Security Council in this year's MoMUN. This will be my 11th conference, and I am confident that we will be able to draft comprehensive resolutions and have fruitful debates!

The topic of this Study Guide is "Maintaining peace and security in the Strait of Hormuz during periods of heightened tensions". The topic has gained renewed international attention following the escalation between Iran and the United States in 2026. That particular area is an important chokepoint, as approximately one-fifth of global petroleum liquids consumption passed through the Strait in 2024. This Study Guide aims to give you a general idea and an introduction, if you will, about the topic. Even though this guide aims to cover the basics about this topic, I strongly encourage you to do some further research on your own.

I look forward to meeting you all at the conference. Until then, should you need anything, please do not hesitate to contact me at sofia.maria.albani@icloud.com or the committee's main chair, Sofia, at svatista18@gmail.com.

Introduction

The issue of "Maintaining peace and security in the Strait of Hormuz during periods of heightened tensions" is a complex and multifaceted issue that requires a deep understanding of the history of the area. The complications in the Strait of Hormuz are caused by a series of events between some countries, and it is mainly centred on the confrontation of the US and Iran, although it has many regional and international dimensions.

The Strait is a maritime chokepoint, as approximately 20% of global petroleum liquids consumption passed through this point in 2024. Before 2026, the Strait operated through the Traffic Separation Scheme (TSS). But the reason as to why this issue has come up again at the forefront of today's current affairs is the situation after the crisis of February 2026. After the killing of the Iranian Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Iran retaliated and closed off the Strait of Hormuz, while also releasing many missiles that were targeted at Israel, the US, and other Gulf States. To this day, the traffic

through the Strait has not been able to return to what it was before, meaning the traffic has significantly fallen, and the price of oil has gone up.

This issue has come before the Security Council, as there is a significant threat to international security posed by the relationship between Iran and the US. As the UN Charter states in Article 39, the SC may determine whether a situation is a threat to the peace, a breach of peace, or an act of aggression, and blockades, attacks on merchant ships or threats to close the Strait may meet that threshold. In other words, the aforementioned actions of the countries involved pose a threat to international peace, so for this reason we have this agenda topic.

The main issue at hand is: "How can we as the SC maintain peace and security in that area during times of heightened tension?" This means that when there is something actively happening there, whether that is between the US and Iran or other countries that actively affect the Strait, how can we ensure that peace talks are happening and that harm can be minimised.

Key Terms and Definitions

Strait of Hormuz

"The Strait of Hormuz is a narrow channel, approximately 30 miles wide at the narrowest point, between the Omani Musandam Peninsula and Iran. It connects the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman".[1]

Blockade

"The situation in which a country or place is surrounded by soldiers or ships to stop people or goods from going in or out."[2]

Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG)

"Natural gas (primarily methane) that has been liquefied for ease of storing and transporting. Liquefied natural gas (LNG) occupies approximately 1/600 of the volume of natural gas in its gaseous state, and it can be easily shipped overseas."[3]

[1]Strait of Hormuz - geography - Strauss center. (n.d.-f). https://www.strausscenter.org/strait-of-hormuz-geography/

[2]Blockade | English meaning - Cambridge Dictionary. (n.d.-c). https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/blockade

[3] Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) | description, uses, & benefits | Britannica. (n.d.-y). https://www.britannica.com/science/liquefied-natural-gas

Iran's Revolutionary Guard Corps

"The IRGC is one of the most powerful organizations in Iran, conceived as the principal defender of the 1979 revolution, and now a critical link to Islamist militant groups violently opposed to Israel and the United States."[4]

Musandam Peninsula

"Peninsula, a northeastern extension of the Arabian Peninsula, separating the Gulf of Oman on the east from the Persian Gulf on the west to form the Strait of Hormuz to the north."[5]

Six-Day War of June 1967

"Brief war that took place June 5–10, 1967, and was the third of the Arab-Israeli wars. Israel's decisive victory included the capture of the Sinai Peninsula, Gaza Strip, West Bank, Old City of Jerusalem, and Golan Heights."[6]

Freedom of navigation

"The right of innocent passage through a coastal State's territorial sea is defined as "navigation through the territorial sea for the purpose of (a) traversing that sea without entering internal waters or calling at a roadstead or port facility outside internal waters; or (b) proceeding to or from internal waters or a call at such roadstead or port facility." Passage must be "continuous and expeditious," but it may include stopping and anchoring when incidental to ordinary navigation or rendered necessary by unusual circumstances"[7]

Transit passage

"Transit passage means the exercise in accordance with this Part of the freedom of navigation and overflight solely for the purpose of continuous and expeditious transit of the strait between one part of the high seas or an exclusive economic zone and another part of the high seas or an exclusive economic zone. However, the requirement of continuous and expeditious transit does not preclude passage through the strait for the purpose of entering, leaving or returning from a State bordering the strait, subject to the conditions of entry to that State."[8]

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[4] The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) | council on foreign relations. (n.d.-am). https://www.cfr.org/backgrounders/irans-revolutionary-guards

[5] Musandam Peninsula | Oman, United Arab Emirates, Persian Gulf, map, & facts | britannica. (n.d.-ab). https://www.britannica.com/place/Musandam-Peninsula

[6] Six-Day War | Definition, causes, history, summary, outcomes, & facts | britannica. (n.d.-ah). https://www.britannica.com/event/Six-Day-War

[7] Chapter 3: Freedom of navigation – law of the sea. (n.d.-g). https://sites.tufts.edu/lawofthesea/chapter-three/

[8] Law Insider. (2025, July 6). *Transit passage definition*. https://www.lawinsider.com/dictionary/transit-passage

Territorial sea

"The waters under the sovereign jurisdiction of a nation or state, extending up to 12 nautical miles from legally determined baselines, distinct from internal waters."[9]

UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)

"The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea was adopted in 1982 and entered into force in 1994. It lays down a comprehensive regime of law and order for the world's oceans, establishing rules for the allocation of States' rights and jurisdiction in maritime spaces, the peaceful use of the oceans and the management of their resources. The Convention also provides a framework for the further development of specific areas of the law of the sea, including through the work of competent international organizations such as IMO." This treaty has been ratified by Oman, but not by Iran, meaning that treaty obligations vary.[10]

Maritime Chokepoint

"A chokepoint refers to the point of natural congestion along two broader and more critical navigable passages. Maritime choke points are naturally narrow shipping channels with high traffic because of their strategic locations. They are vital for global trade."[11]

Arabian Peninsula

"Arabia, a peninsular region, together with offshore islands, located in the extreme southwestern corner of Asia. The Arabian Peninsula is bounded by the Red Sea on the west and southwest, the Gulf of Aden on the south, the Arabian Sea on the south and southeast, and the Gulf of Oman and the Persian Gulf (also called the Arabian Gulf) on the east. Geographically, the peninsula and the Syrian Desert merge in the north with no clear line of demarcation, but the northern boundaries of Saudi Arabia and of Kuwait are generally taken as marking the limit of Arabia there."[12]

Expansionism

"increasing the amount of land ruled by a country, or the business performed by a company".[13]

Tariffs

"A tariff is a tax levied upon goods as they cross national boundaries, usually by the government of the importing country."[14]

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[9] Territorial waters definition & meaning - merriam-webster. (n.d.-ap). https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/territorial%20waters

[10] United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea. (n.d.-aw). https://www.imo.org/en/ourwork/legal/pages/unitednationsconventiononthelawofthesea.aspx

[11] What are maritime chokepoints? (n.d.-ay). https://www.marineinsight.com/what-are-maritime-chokepoints/

[12] Arabia | Definition, history, countries, map, & facts | britannica. (n.d.-f). https://www.britannica.com/place/Arabia-peninsula-Asia

[13] Cambridge dictionary: Find definitions, meanings & translations. (n.d.-h). https://dictionary.cambridge.org/us/

[14] Tariff | Definition, types, examples, & facts | britannica money. (n.d.-bf).

Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ)

"Exclusive economic zone (EEZ), as defined under the 1982 United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), is an area of the ocean extending up to 200 nautical miles (370 km) immediately offshore from a country's land coast in which that country retains sovereign rights for the exploration, exploitation, conservation and management of natural resources."[15]

Background Information

General Information about the Strait

Geographical Characteristics

The Strait of Hormuz, which is bordered by Iran and Oman, is located between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman. The strait has always been a critical point of commerce, as it connects the Persian Gulf with the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea. It also provides the principal maritime outlet for several Gulf energy exporters.[16] Although this passage is of great importance to the global market, it is structurally vulnerable. That vulnerability is its narrowness. The Strait is only 30 miles wide; that is less than 50 km, meaning that when a disruption takes place, it is very easy for the traffic in the area to slow down. So when a disruption does take place, the price of the goods that pass through gets elevated.



Figure 1: The Strait of Hormuz[17]

[15] Exclusive Economic Zone | definition, examples, distance, international law, EEZ, & map | Britannica. (n.d.-ad). https://www.britannica.com/topic/exclusive-economic-zone

[16] How did the Hormuz Strait Form? - AAPG | advancing petroleum geosciences since 1917. (n.d.-r). https://www.aapg.org/news-and-media/explorer/how-did-the-hormuz-strait-form/

[17] Strait of Hormuz | map, importance, conflict and closure, control, oil, & facts | britannica. (n.d.-e). https://www.britannica.com/place/Strait-of-Hormuz

Territorial Jurisdiction

In the Strait, two navigational routes pass through the territorial seas of Oman and Iran.[18] These lanes are separated into the *Inbound lane,* which goes into the Persian Gulf and is on the Iranian side, and the *Outbound lane,* which goes towards the Gulf of Oman and is on the side of Oman. At the narrowest point of the Strait, the lanes pass through the territorial waters of both countries[19]. These passages fall under the scope of the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), which creates the right of transit passage. This right essentially enables all vessels to pass through such straits, and it prevents countries from closing off those passages. Now, an important question that needs to be answered here is: Which states exercise sovereignty over the territorial seas forming the Strait, and what navigational rights do foreign vessels possess? So, as mentioned before, the shipping lanes fall mostly under the Omani territorial sea, and partially under the Iranian territorial sea, and they both retain sovereignty and certain regulatory powers *over their territorial seas*, subject to the legal regime governing transit passage. International law limits how that authority may be exercised, but it does not eliminate coastal governance. As coastal countries, they retain important responsibilities regarding navigational safety, pollution control and maritime regulation. These navigational arrangements are addressed by Articles 37–44 of UNCLOS; Iran is not a party, so the treaty obligations of the two coastal states differ.

Strategic Vulnerabilities of the Strait

The issue is that, although the Strait is not owned by any country, Iran's proximity and naval capabilities mean that it can disrupt traffic, as demonstrated by events in February 2026. This is because of its strong military power and due to the aforementioned geography of the area. For these reasons, Iran has the capacity to disrupt the navigation of the Strait. International forces have intervened in the past to ensure safe passage, but the proximity of the Strait to Iran's shores gives Iran the advantage of dominating the Strait. [20] So, due to its position, Iran can easily use the Strait as political leverage and put pressure on its foes.

[18]The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica (2026, July 14). How does the geography of the Strait of Hormuz affect its role in global shipping? . Encyclopedia Britannica. https://www.britannica.com/question/How-does-the-geography-of-the-Strait-of-Hormuz-affect-its-role-in-global-shipping

[19] *Reaching viable management arrangements in the Strait of Hormuz*. The Washington Institute. (n.d.). https://www.washingtoninstitute.org/policy-analysis/reaching-viable-management-arrangements-strait-hormuz

[20] The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica (2026, July 14). Who owns the Strait of Hormuz? Encyclopedia Britannica. https://www.britannica.com/question/Who-owns-the-Strait-of-Hormuz

The IMO Traffic Separation Scheme (TSS)

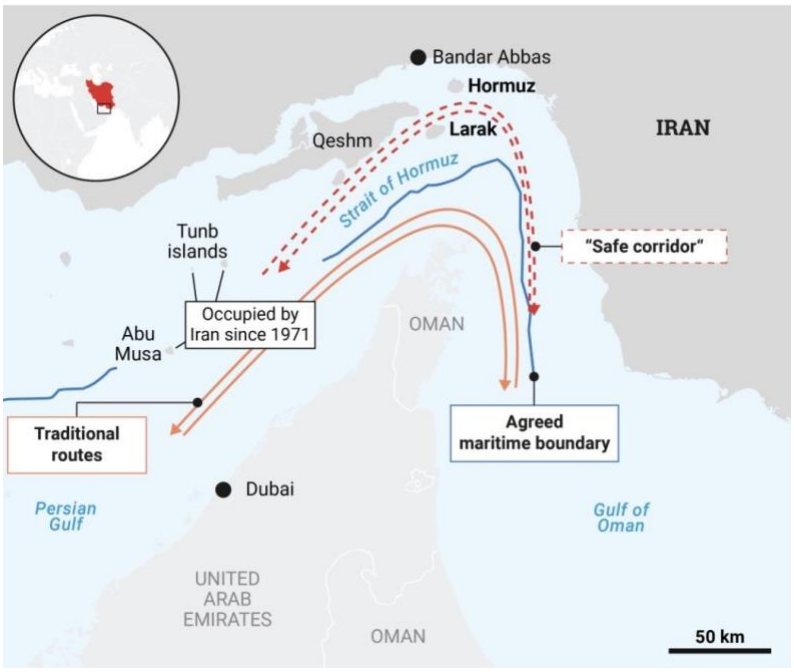


Figure 2: map of the former lanes and the ones created after the crisis of February 2026.[21]

In the image above, we can see the traditional trade routes and the ones after the crisis of February 2026. Before the crisis, the way that the Strait operated was developed through international maritime routing arrangements before 2026. That is what we can call the Traffic Separation Scheme (TSS). The routing arrangements were subsequently adopted through the International Maritime Organization (IMO), aiming to reduce the collision risk in the area.22 It was basically composed of two lanes: one that was designated for ships to go into the Strait and one from which they would leave. In 2026, Iran unilaterally created a corridor after the imposition of the blockade, and it is currently the way that the Strait is operating. In other words, there has been a new "safe corridor" under which the ships follow and go through the Strait, which falls under the Iranian territorial waters and adjacent maritime areas. Instead of the ships crossing both the territorial waters of Iran and Oman, now they have to do so over the island of Larak, which falls under Iranian sovereignty.23 These corridors are completely separate from the TSS, and they are not the same, in any way, shape, or form.

[21] Strait of Hormuz: Chinese cargo ship pays to use Iran Corridor • table.briefings. (n.d.-ah). https://table.media/en/china/news-en/strait-of-hormuz-chinese-cargo-ship-pStrait's operationays-to-use-iran-corridor
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[22] *Information related to shipping and seafarers - Strait of Hormuz and the Middle East.* International Maritime Organisation . (n.d.). https://www.imo.org/en/mediacentre/hottopics/pages/middle-east-strait-of-hormuz.aspx

[23] A visual guide to Iran's coastline and Strategic Islands. (n.d.-c). https://interactive.aljazeera.com/aje/2026/iran-coastline-islands/

Energy and Commercial Significance

This geographical area is considered to be one of the most important areas for global shipping, as approximately one-fifth of global petroleum liquids consumption and global liquefied natural gas (LNG) trade passed through it in 2024. Daily, before the crisis of February 2026, 80-130 ships passed through that point, many of which were oil tankers. The amount of oil that passes daily through that area is vital for the continuation of the global supply chain in the oil market. Yearly, before the closure of the Strait, roughly 30,000 cargo ships passed through that passage.[24] The closure or severe restriction can increase oil prices, insurance premiums, freight costs, and uncertainty while exposing states with limited alternative export capacity.

Let's take as an example what happened on the 28th of February 2026. After the killing of the leader of Iran, Iran's Revolutionary Guard Corps closed off the Strait, which resulted in approximately 150 vessels that were already in the area dropping anchor and the daily traffic rate being reduced from 150 ships per day to less than 20. Oil prices subsequently rose sharply, althoug[25]h the comparison with January prices does not represent a[26] one-day increase.

Historical Background

The British Influence in the Gulf

The Strait of Hormuz has been a strategic commercial point for almost 2,000 years, leading many states, including the British Empire, to try to control it. Although Britain never claimed the Strait, it influenced areas that are now Oman and the UAE, including by bombarding the Musandam Peninsula in 1930 to force the surrender of an local tribal resistance.[27]

In 1968, Britain faced an economic crisis amid pressure on sterling and economic constraints. The government decided to withdraw British military forces from "East of Suez," creating a security

[24] The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica (2026, July 14). How many ships pass through the Strait of Hormuz? . Encyclopedia Britannica. https://www.britannica.com/question/How-many-ships-pass-through-the-Strait-of-Hormuz

[25] Lessons from the Strait of Hormuz Crisis | Blavatnik school of government. (n.d.-w). https://www.bsg.ox.ac.uk/blog/lessons-strait-hormuz-crisis

[26]Oil prices hover around four-month high, buoyed by Iran concerns, weak dollar | reuters. (n.d.-ax). https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/oil-prices-mixed-us-supply-worries-linger-after-winter-storm-2026-01-28/

[27] Why the Strait of Hormuz has been a global commerce chokepoint f...or centuries - the globe and mail. (n.d.-au). https://www.theglobeandmail.com/world/article-strait-of-hormuz,,,-iran-history-explainer/ ,.

vacuum in the Persian Gulf.[28] Britain had been a major foreign power in the region since the eighteenth century, and Bahrain, Qatar, and the Trucial States had signed protection treaties allowing Britain to control their defence and foreign policies.[29]

By the 1970s, Britain sought to maintain influence through Oman, which relied heavily on Britain. Britain supported Omani military operations during a period of regional insurgency. On 17 December 1970, the SAS was deployed to support operations in Oman, and the campaign was successful.[30]

By 1971, Bahrain and Qatar were independent, while Abu Dhabi, Dubai, and five other emirates planned to form the UAE. Iran claimed three disputed islands administered by the emirates of Sharjah and Ras al-Khaimah before the formation of the UAE. An audiotape later revealed discussions between Iran's Shah and Britain's Foreign Secretary about Iran's claim to the islands.[31] Although Britain publicly stated that the islands belonged to the Trucial States, December 1971 marked the last time the UK controlled the area before withdrawing completely.[32]

War of Iran-Iraq

The Iran–Iraq War and the Tanker War significantly changed Gulf security by turning the Strait of Hormuz and surrounding waters into a militarized conflict zone. [33]Attacks on oil tankers and vessels linked to Iran or its allies increased the need for naval protection and made commercial shipping more expensive and dangerous.[34]

Iran's use of asymmetric tactics and later HY-2 Silkworm missiles expanded the threat to shipping and regional oil infrastructure. Kuwait's request for U.S. protection led to Operation Earnest Will,

28 How Britain seized the Strait of Hormuz through blood and coercion – Sri Lanka Guardian. (n.d.-e). https://slguardian.org/how-britain-seized-the-strait-of-hormuz-through-blood-and-coercion/

Chowdhury, A. (2026, September 7). *When Britain used torture to control the Strait of Hormuz*. Declassified UK. https://www.declassifieduk.org/when-britain-used-torture-to-control-the-strait-of-hormuz/

29 How Britain seized the Strait of Hormuz through blood and coercion – Sri Lanka Guardian. (n.d.-e). https://slguardian.org/how-britain-seized-the-strait-of-hormuz-through-blood-and-coercion/

30 Secret deals ending Britain's control in the Gulf were revealed. (n.d.-ag). https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-62713025

31 Secret deals ending Britain's control in the Gulf were revealed. (n.d.-ag). https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-62713025

32 Secret deals ending Britain's control in the Gulf were revealed. (n.d.-ag). https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-62713025

33 Iranian Revolution (1979) | summary, causes, effects, Islamic Republic, Ayatollah, & facts | britannica. (n.d.-x). https://www.britannica.com/event/Iranian-Revolution

34 Iran-iraq war | causes, summary, casualties, chemical weapons, dates, & facts | britannica. (n.d.-e). https://www.britannica.com/event/Iran-Iraq-War

increasing the role of external military powers in protecting energy routes and strengthening the U.S. naval presence in the Gulf.[35]

The conflict also encouraged greater international involvement in Gulf security. The Security Council adopted Resolution 598 in 1987, demanding an immediate ceasefire and the cessation of military actions, as well as addressing attacks on shipping and civilian aircraft. Overall, the war shifted Gulf security from a mainly regional concern to an internationalized system in which outside powers helped govern and protect energy routes.[36]

Gulf War of 1991

Later on, by the end of the war between Iran and Iraq, a new war emerged, called the Gulf War. By the end of the former war, Iraq was deep in debt to the Gulf creditors, amounting to approximately $37 billion. The then Iraqi president, Saddam Hussein, called on Kuwait and the UAE to cancel their debts, as they should view what had happened as a protection of the Arab Peninsula from Iran's expansionism. Those countries refused to write off that debt, so Iraq decided to threaten Kuwait. The threat was that Saddam would reignite the long-standing question of the ownership of two islands. All this resulted in Kuwait being invaded on 2 August 1990 by Iraqi troops, the imposition of sanctions and an embargo by the UN Security Council, and the beginning of an air and ground war between those countries and a US alliance. This began on 17 January 1991 and ended on 28 February 1991, with the loss of Iraq and the retreat from Kuwait.[37] Again, this war, like the one before, had a lasting impact on the Strait and the people living around it. Not only are we talking about price fluctuations but also about the area's geopolitical significance. We have seen the impact of many wars on the Strait and how it is used for other countries' agendas. This is exactly what makes the Strait of Hormuz a geopolitical chokepoint, not only the number of ships that pass through but also the fact that many countries want to control it or use it as a means to put pressure on their foes.

Recent Developments

Context of the events of 28 February 2026

One of the main recent developments in the Strait of Hormuz is the war that started between Iran and the US. But their history goes way back before February 2026. The long-standing hostility and

[35] United Nations. (n.d.). *Security council resolution 598: Iraq-Islamic Republic of Iran | Peacemaker*. United Nations. https://peacemaker.un.org/en/node/9413

[36] Why and how are we blockading Iranian ports in the Strait of Hormuz? (n.d.-bd). https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/c5yv6xr6me3o

[37] Milestones in the history of U.S. Foreign Relations - Office of the historian. (n.d.-ac). https://history.state.gov/milestones/1989-1992/gulf-war

mistrust between the two countries began in 1953, when the US helped overthrow Iran's Prime Minister Mohammad Mosaddegh in a coup that strengthened the Shah's authority.[38]

Later on, in 1979, with the Iranian Revolution, things took a turn for the worse, due to the so-called "embassy hostage crisis". Essentially, during that time, the people of Iran were deeply unsatisfied with their ruler, Mohammad Reza Shah Pahlavi, who was very close to the US government and faced opposition from several political movements. In November 1979, militants seized the US embassy in Tehran and held 52 American diplomats and citizens hostage for 444 days.[39]

After the US understood the dismay of the people of Iran, it shifted its focus to Iraq and the reign of Saddam Hussein. In the 1980s, it is said that the US prolonged the war between Iran and Iraq due to its personal interests in the Gulf region, which resulted in the further weakening of the already weakened Iran. After the invasion of Kuwait in 1990, the US led a coalition against Iraq, as the US led a coalition against Iraq after Iraq invaded Kuwait. In that particular decade, the US also imposed economic sanctions that took place with the stated reason for the disarmament of Iraq of weapons of mass destruction and the protection of the allies in the Gulf. [40] During that period in time, it became crystal clear that the US had interests in the region, and that is also reflected in the dynamic of the two today.

28 February- 11 March

The most recent development in the relationship between the US and Iran, which also involves the Strait of Hormuz, is the war that started on 28 February 2026. This war was initiated by the US and Israel, and the main event that triggered Iran was the killing of the Supreme Leader of the Iranian regime, Ali Khamenei. This resulted in Iran launching repeated missile and drone attacks in the area, which left many dead in countries like Iran, Lebanon, the Gulf Arab states, and Israel. This was a so-called "retaliatory campaign", meaning a series of attacks that aimed to "punish" the countries that Iran believed to be responsible for Khamenei's death. After that, the traffic in the Strait was cut almost completely, to virtually no reported transits on 4 March 2026.[41] During that time, there were also attacks on merchant vessels, after the traffic started to get better, that imposed great risk to the people navigating it. So because this issue was actively affecting one of the most important areas of global shipping, since then there have been many tries to solve the issue, either

[38] US and Iran: A brief history of how decades of mistrust and bad blood led to open warfare. (n.d.-bc). https://theconversation.com/us-and-iran-a-brief-history-of-how-decades-of-mistrust-and-bad-blood-led-to-open-warfare-279712

[39] Iran hostage crisis | definition, summary, causes, significance, & facts | britannica. (n.d.-z). https://www.britannica.com/event/Iran-hostage-crisis

[40] *The Human Cost of U.S. Interventions in Iraq: A History From the 1960s Through the Post-9/11 Wars*. Brown University, Watson Institute. (n.d.). https://costsofwar.watson.brown.edu/sites/default/files/papers/Saleh-US-Interventions-in-Iraq.pdf

[41] *Iran War: See How Tanker Traffic Collapsed in the Strait of Hormuz | Reuters*, www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/iran-war-see-how-tanker-traffic-collapsed-strait-hormuz-2026-03-06/.

through diplomatic talks arranged by Oman or by the creation of SC resolutions, like Resolution 2817.[42]

Closure and Shipping Disruptions on the Strait

After that, Iran imposed a blockade of the Strait, meaning the traffic of the Strait was significantly cut down, and the only ships that were permitted to enter were the ones that were approved by Iran's Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC). While Iran was blocking the Strait, the US Navy forces were blocking most of the ships that were going from and to Iran, while the price of a barrel of oil was actively increasing. Iran was also attacking ships and other countries' territories at the time that the Strait was closed off.[43] Iran announced a reopening on 16 April 2026, with the term that if the blockade of the US persisted, then it would be closed off again. [44]

Bahrain-US Resolution of June 2026

Bahrain was one of the first countries to propose a diplomatic way to solve the issue, with the proposal of a UN draft resolution. This resolution is based on Resolution 2817 and is specifically aimed at addressing the threats to commercial navigation. The main requests of this resolution include the halt of attacks from Iran on commercial and merchant vessels, the stop of interference with international navigation, the abstention from the imposition of tolls or other kinds of fees upon the entrance or the departure of the Strait, and the need for international cooperation efforts so a humanitarian corridor can be established. Although this separate proposal was discussed, it was not adopted as a Security Council resolution. Essentially, even though the proposal was not formally adopted, it did put political pressure, and it further established the need for the UN to take a clearer stance on the matter as a whole, as well as the need for a solution for the Strait of the problem as a whole.[45]

Adoption of Resolution 2817

Resolution 2817 was the response of the SC to what was happening in the Strait in late February. This was adopted on 11 March 2026, and essentially, this resolution's purpose was to condemn Iranian attacks against neighbouring countries and to try to get the Strait to open again.[46] This resolution has

[42] 2026 Iran war | Deal, explained, United States, Israel, Strait of Hormuz, map, & conflict | britannica. (n.d.-b). https://www.britannica.com/event/2026-Iran-warno vessels are passingno vessels are passing

[43] What is the Strait of Hormuz and why is Iran blocking it? - The New York Times. (n.d.-bj). https://www.nytimes.com/2026/03/12/world/middleeast/strait-of-hormuz-iran-blockade-explained.html

[44] Iran says Strait of Hormuz 'completely open' but sounds warning on US blockade | Strait of hormuz | the guardian. ,n.d.-ab). https://www.theguardian.com/world/2026/apr/17/strait-of-hormuz-now-open-to-commercial-vessels ,

[45] Bahrain and US Float Security Council resolution on the Strait of Hormuz | UN news. (n.d.-h). https://news.un.org/en/story/2026/05/1167464Also,

[46] United Nations. (n.d.-a). *Security Council adopts Resolution 2817 (2026) condemning Iran's "egregious attacks" against neighbours as Middle East violence rapidly escalates | UN meetings coverage and press releases*. United Nations. https://press.un.org/en/2026/sc16315.doc.htm

significantly helped the situation, as it condemns the attacks that Iran was carrying out against countries like Kuwait and Oman, it demanded the immediate cessation of Iranian attacks against the named neighbouring states, and it was against any threats from Iran to close off the Strait or disrupt its traffic in any way or form.

Current Situation

Information in this section is current as of the 21st of September 2026.

Maritime security and Physical Activity

Currently, even though the Strait of Hormuz has formally opened, things have not yet gone back to what they were before. In reality, although it was formally announced that the Strait had opened, as of August 2026, the IMO recorded low traffic rates, with the largest number of vessels passing through in a day being approximately 23. [47] In recent weeks (August 2026), the levels of traffic have started to resemble those at the start of the conflict. In other words, the traffic in the Strait of Hormuz has been so little lately that experts have started to compare it with that of the beginning of March. [48] Another aspect of the commercial trade that has been affected and compromised is the safety of the Strait and the route that many ships have to follow. Due to the instability in the area, many major routes in the area are thought to be dangerous for such ships to pass through. While there is the alternative solution of taking local routes, it is thought that for such a thing to be coordinated and for it to happen safely, it would take a lot of time and effort, due to the strict local laws. Thus, this is considered to be very hard to happen, and that is the very reason that it has not happened yet.[49]

Humanitarian and Environmental Consequences

A persisting issue in the Strait is the fact that vessels pass through the Strait while sailing "dark", meaning that they may disable or manipulate their Automatic Identification System (AIS) to reduce publicly available tracking or conceal their identity and movement, but they may still be detected through radar, satellites, and other surveillance systems. This is happening due to an announcement made by Tehran that the Strait is closed off, regardless of Washington's statements that the Strait remains open, while the embargo is still standing.[50] Additionally, an issue that is interfering with the safe passage through the Strait is the fact that there are still military attacks happening. The US is attacking Iran while Iran is attacking the US, making that area high risk for a complication to occur

[47] *Monthly data on transits of ships through the Strait of Hormuz*. International Maritime Organization. (n.d.). https://www.imo.org/en/mediacentre/hottopics/pages/strait-of-hormuz-middle-east-data.aspx

[48] Shipping insider says "nothing is going through" The Strait of Hormuz, despite U.S. insisting it's open - CBS News. (n.d.-aq). https://www.cbsnews.com/news/iran-war-strait-of-hormuz-not-open-red-sea-bab-el-mandeb/

[49] *Shipping Rackets and Sea Mines: The New Normal in Hormuz after 17 Weeks*. (n.d.). *YouTube.com*. Retrieved from https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r0EvQgLcjMw&t=555s.

[50] Ships transit Hormuz in secret as US and Iran trade strikes. (n.d.-ar). https://www.insurancejournal.com/news/international/2026/07/13/877286.htm

and a ship to become collateral. [51]The navigational risk persists, as there is still escalating friction between the US and Iran.[52] As of 27 July 2026, the IMO listed 62 confirmed incidents and 17 seafarer fatalities in the Strait, showcasing that what is happening right now in the Strait is dangerous towards innocent civilians and it also demonstrates the need for a solution.[53]

Economic and Energy Consequences

Another issue that is persisting, even though the Strait is open, is the fact that many vessels and oil tankers are stalling and not going through. This aspect of the issue remains of great importance, as through the Strait and the Persian Gulf more than 20% of the global supply of oil passes through before being delivered. This is creating a problem not only for the supply chain but also for the price of a barrel of oil, as the demand for the oil gets higher while the supply of the product becomes less.[54] Furthermore, a recent economic development is the fact that the IRGC has put up a de facto toll booth; their vessels are asked to provide thorough documentation, and they have to obtain a special clearance to proceed, while being escorted by the IRGC. While not all the vessels have had the obligation to pay, there have been two documented cases where they have been asked to do so. In hindsight, this type of toll booth is further controlling the traffic of the Strait and further cutting it back to approximately 15 per day.[55]

Diplomacy and Legal Disagreement

As far as the diplomatic aspect of the issue is concerned, many UN agencies are calling for more negotiations between the US and Iran. To be more specific, the UN's Secretary-General is demanding more diplomatic talks, while several UN agencies, like the IMO, are actively condemning the behaviour of the two and the attacks on civilians. Although the previously drafted resolution is deemed to have fallen through, the UN is recognising the need for a new resolution and a solution in general, while also acknowledging the already existing treaties and documents that need to be applied in the situation. An example can be Articles 37-44 of UNCLOS, which specifically include the right of transit passage, meaning that ships and aircraft enjoy transit-passage rights under the Convention, subject to its conditions. Articles 37-44 essentially establish transit passage, from Article 37, which defines the scope to which these Articles may be applied, to Articles 39 and 40, which establish duties of the passing vessels, Articles 41-43, which mandate the way countries that are on

[51] Strait of Hormuz Live Tracker — real-time shipping & oil crisis monitor. (n.d.-az). https://hormuzstraitmonitor.com/

[52] Team, T. E. (2026, September 7). *Iran threatens Hormuz Exclusion Zone as vessel traffic hits new low*. SAFETY4SEA. https://safety4sea.com/iran-threatens-hormuz-exclusion-zone-as-vessel-traffic-hits-new-low/

[53] Strait of Hormuz: Un agencies call for diplomacy to end attacks | UN news. (n.d.-ba). https://news.un.org/en/story/2026/07/1167929

[54] Scientists warn of possible invasive species superspreader event due to stalling near Strait of Hormuz - ABC News. (n.d.-ap). https://abcnews.com/International/scientists-warn-invasive-species-superspreader-event-due-stalling/story?id=135051186

[55] Tehran's 'toll Booth' system is now controlling Hormuz Traffic :: Lloyd's List. (n.d.-bc). https://www.lloydslist.com/LL1156720/Tehrans-toll-booth-system-is-now-controlling-Hormuz-traffic

the Strait may collaborate to create a way for ships to pass, and finally Article 44, which requires states bordering the Strait not to hamper transit passage. In other words, these Articles establish the legal regime of transit passage in international straits.

Overall, the issue has been longstanding, and it has not been solved to the extent that it should have. In late July 2026, there were renewed Iranian attacks and US strikes that escalated the conflict again, despite many diplomatic efforts.[56] As of late September 2026, the Strait is effectively restricted and not actively reopened, meaning that the issue is still persisting and an effective solution has not been found. Reportedly, on the weekend of the 19th and 20th of September 2026, only 37 vessels passed through the Strait.[57] Last but not least, there have been reports from the IMO that report that more than 20,000 seafarers, port workers, and offshore personnel have been affected by the situation, and there has been an evacuation framework established for stranded ships. This shows the immediate humanitarian issue and the need for a solution to be found.

Timeline of Events

Date	Description of Event
1930	Britain's navy forces bombarded the Musandam peninsula.
1953	The US helped overthrow the prime minister of Iran.
June 1967	Six-Day War.
1968	Economic crisis and crash of the pound.
December 1970	Last time the UK influenced the Gulf States.
1979	Iranian Revolution.
1979	The US embassy hostage crisis.
1980	Start of the war between Iran and Iraq.
1988	End of the aforementioned war.

[56] "Iran Update Special Report, July 31, 2026." *Critical Threats*, www.criticalthreats.org/analysis/iran-update-special-report-july-31-2026.

[57] *Vessels Trickle through Strait of Hormuz as Middle East ...*, www.reuters.com/world/middle-east/vessels-trickle-through-strait-hormuz-mideast-tension-persists-2026-09-21.

2 August 1990	Iraq invades Kuwait and the Gulf War starts
17 January 1991	Coalition military operations against Iraq begin.
28 February 2026	Death of Iran's supreme leader Ali Khamenei.
Beginning of March 2026	Iran closes off the Strait of Hormuz, while the US later imposes maritime restrictions on Iran.
16 April 2026	Iran announces the reopening of the Strait, although shipping remains disrupted.

Major Actors Involved

Iran

Iran has been one of the most involved countries in the issue of the Strait of Hormuz. Its history with the US, the critical role in the Strait and the political decisions, like to close off the Strait, make it one of the most important actors on the issue. Although Iran has been involved in negotiations for a ceasefire with the US, there has been no effective outcome that has lasted.

United States of America (USA)

Since the middle of the 20th century, the US has been actively involved in the internal affairs of many of the Gulf States, while also allegedly fueling the Tanker War, escorting reflagged Kuwaiti tankers, supporting Iraq at different stages of the situation, and now the confrontation with Iranian forces. The interests of the US have been clear almost since the start, as in that area there are many oil-rich countries worth having as allies. So the US has been a major actor in the history of the Strait and also during the latest developments.

Oman

Oman has been actively involved in the issue, not only because of its exports that go through the Strait, but also because it has played a big part in the negotiations for a solution. Alongside the US, it proposed a resolution to halt the strikes; it also has importance in the Strait due to its position, as it actively touches the waters of the Strait. The interests of this country are great in the area, as before February 2026 there was an active navigation route that fell under its sovereignty.

Gulf States

The Gulf States, namely the UAE, Bahrain, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Iraq, and Qatar, have been involved to a great extent in the issue of the Strait. Since most of these are countries that export oil through the area, the Strait is one of the most effective ways that they can transport their oil. So they have high-stakes interests in that area. Not only that, but they have also been affected by the ongoing war between the US and Iran, due to their geographical position.

International Maritime Organisation (IMO)

The IMO is very actively involved in the whole issue of the Strait. Even though it does not have binding authority, it develops international conventions, routing systems, and safety standards, and the implementation and enforcement primarily rest with member states; it has played an important role in trying to resolve the issue. It has actively shown its dismay with the situation, while also trying to ensure that the vessels passing through the Strait are safely doing so. [58]

United Nations Security Council (UNSC)

The Security Council has tried to solve the issue in the past. It adopted Resolution 2817 on 11 March 2026, which contributed significantly to showing the dismay of many Member States over the Iranian attacks on other countries. Generally, this resolution showed the clear position of the UN and its member states on the situation.

Israel

Israel has been involved in the issue of the Strait, not because it's a coastal country, but because of security threats and because it was involved in the operation that killed Ali Khamenei. Because of this, it is immediately associated with the issue, and it clearly stands against the closure of the Strait. It supports that the freedom of navigation needs to be preserved and that the Strait should not be closed off and that there need to be vessels passing.

India

India has chosen to stay neutral and not adopt a clear position on the matter, but they have supported the need for the freedom of navigation, protection of commercial shipping and diplomatic de-escalation, as well as the reopening of the Strait. Although it has been firm on these facts, it has not chosen a stance on the dispute between Iran and the US. India's stance is important to the matter, as 40% of its oil imports pass through the Strait, and some of its citizens had been trapped in the Strait when it was closed off. So even though India has not taken a clear stance between the two key actors involved, or has been actively involved, it agrees that there needs to be a solution for this issue, so that the Strait remains open.

China

China stands with the reopening of the Strait and is pro-de-escalation; it also opposes the blockade imposed by the US and is against the relevant SC resolutions. Although it is supportive of the reopening and the usage of the Strait, it also goes against such resolutions because they feel like they are biased towards Iran, due to the fact that China is one of the main customers of Iran and it depends a lot on the Arabian Gulf shipping.

58 India's energy security at a crossroads: The Hormuz Crisis and an opportunity for US-india cooperation - atlantic council. (n.d.-j). https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/blogs/energysource/indias-energy-security-at-a-crossroads-the-hormuz-crisis-and-an-opportunity-for-us-india-cooperation/

UN Documents and International Agreements

United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)[59]

The UNCLOS is an International Treaty that mandates the rules for all of the oceans and marine life, and establishes rules for territorial seas, exclusive economic zones, continental shelves, and other maritime zones. It is highly relevant to this topic, as this treaty has stipulated what the right of navigation is and how vessels can move through the waters. The Convention provides a central legal framework for assessing restrictions on navigation, although Iran is not a party and the application of customary international law remains relevant. To be more specific, Articles 37-44 of the present Convention create a non-suspensible passage regime, meaning these Articles create an environment where the passage should never be closed off. Article 37 defines the scope, meaning where these rules can be applied, and Article 38 establishes the right of transit passage, meaning that all ships may pass through a passage, such as the Strait, without creating impediments. Now, Articles 39 and 40 establish duties of vessels and aircraft in transit. This includes proceeding without delays, refraining from the use of force, the impairment of the right of passage, and the prohibition of bordering states from imposing requirements for entering the straits. Additionally, Articles 41 through 43 create the need for cooperation between bordering states. Article 41 enables the establishment of lanes within the straits, like the ones that the Strait of Hormuz has; Article 42 permits bordering states to adopt laws on the straits that have to do with safe passage and pollution control, and Article 43 further encourages bordering states to create frameworks that will enable pollution control and the continuous passage of ships. Lastly, Article 44 establishes key duties of states bordering straits, like the prohibition of hampering with the transit passage, which Iran has done to the Strait. Restrictions obstructing lawful *passage* raise serious issues under the law of the sea, although the precise treaty and customary-law obligations of Iran require careful distinction.

UN Security Council Resolution 2817 (2026)[60]

This is the resolution that was drafted after the request of Bahrain to resolve the blockade that Iran had imposed on the Strait of Hormuz. Although this resolution has helped the situation to a great extent and has contributed to the reopening of the Strait, it has not fully resolved the crisis, as the Strait has not bounced back to the way that it was before and there is still war happening between the US and Iran, which is affecting other countries as well.

UN Charter[61]

The UN Charter gives the binding authority to the Security Council. Basically, it is what gives the Security Council the authority to operate the way it does and is under Article 25, requires Member

59 UNCLOS_E.PDF. (n.d.-q). https://www.un.org/depts/los/convention_agreements/texts/unclos/unclos_e.pdf

60 UN Security Council Resolution 2817 (2026) - UNDOCS. (n.d.-r). https://docs.un.org/en/s/res/2817(2026)

61 United Nations charter (full text) | United Nations. (n.d.-bl). https://www.un.org/en/about-us/un-charter/full-text

States to carry out its decisions in accordance with the Charter. Essentially, it is what gives the right to the SC to intervene, and under this Charter, the SC adopts its resolutions. Although this document has not been actively recalled in the issue, it remains very valuable to the situation, as it gives the SC the authority that it needs. The Chapters that provide the authority of the SC to adopt its resolutions are Chapters VI and VII. The first one stands for the peaceful settlement, which provides for peaceful settlement of disputes. Chapter VII has to do with the enforcement action of the SC, under which the Council may determine threats to peace and decide on measures, including sanctions or authorisation of force. These Chapters are very important to this issue, because essentially they give the SC the authority to intervene in the situation and try to mediate between the key actors involved, as well as try to find a solution.

SUA Convention[62]

The 1988 Convention for the Suppression of Unlawful Acts against the Safety of Maritime Navigation is an IMO treaty that ensures the prosecution or extradition of people who commit unlawful acts against ships and their personnel. In this case, attacks on ships may fall within the offences covered by this Convention, depending on the facts and applicable jurisdiction. Although it may make the actions against vessels illegal, it does not make the blockade of the Strait illegal; hence, it is not considered a Convention upon which the reopening of the Strait can be requested.

Previous Attempts to Solve the Issue

Diplomatic talks and ceasefire between the US and Iran (2026) [63]

During March 2026, amid Iranian restrictions on shipping and subsequent US measures, both leaders of Iran and the US, Mojtaba Khamenei and Donald Trump respectively, agreed to go through diplomatic talks regarding a ceasefire. Although at first they were thought to have potential, in the end these talks fell through and no actual outcome came of it. This initiative had both strengths and weaknesses. The main one was the creation of a channel for de-escalation, as Trump publicly postponed strikes on Iranian energy infrastructure multiple times. Additionally, the fact that there was a mediation infrastructure, meaning that because contact between the two countries is politically difficult, some countries helped organize indirect talks. In this case, the mediators included regional states, notably Oman and Pakistan.[64] Now, the main weakness of this attempt to solve the issue is the deeply rooted mistrust of the US and Iran. The latter stated many times that they did not believe that these talks would go anywhere and that the former was doing that just to buy some time, in order to

[62] 1 contribution from the International Maritime Organization (IMO). (n.d.-c). https://www.un.org/en/ga/sixth/76/universal_jurisdiction/imo_e.pdf

[63] IHow many times were the US and Iran on the verge of a deal? | US-israel war on iran news | al jazeera. (n.d.-z). https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/6/7/how-many-times-were-the-us-and-iran-on-the-verge-of-a-deal

[64] Staff, N. (2026, March 23). *Trump says the U.S. is in talks with Iran to end the war, which Iran denies*. https://www.npr.org/2026/03/23/nx-s1-5757172/iran-defiant-trump-hormuz

create military plans. [65]Another weakness of these talks is the lack of a clear enforcement plan, meaning there was no agreed mechanism through which the frameworks that would be created would be enforced. In other words, even if there was an actual framework that would guarantee peace, there hadn't been an agreed way through which the actual enforcement of such measures would be ensured.[66] In the end, these talks failed, as the weaknesses were more severe than the strengths of this plan.

UN Security Council tries to solve the issue (2026)[67]

On the 11th of March 2026, the Security Council adopted resolution 2817 that aimed to resolve the issue of Hormuz. 13 countries voted in favour, while China and Russia chose to abstain. Although it condemned Iranian attacks on neighbouring states and threats to obstruct navigation and it discouraged the situation and alleviated a lot of the pressure of the situation, it ultimately failed to completely solve the issue and stop the war between the US and Iran. The Strait, even though it's open today it has not bounced back due to many of the things that the IRGC is doing, like the tolls. Also, the war that is still happening causes a huge humanitarian violation, and reports by June 2026 described substantial casualties in Iran, although figures vary by source.[68]

IMO's evacuation framework

Between the 23rd and the 26th of June 2026, the IMO organised an evacuation framework for vessels and seafarers stranded in the Gulf region. This was done in collaboration with Iran, Oman, and other coastal countries. It was not a permanent agreement that sought the reopening of the Strait, but rather it was a means to help stranded people. This system worked with an alternative route that was not the TSS, and it was later reported by the IMO that 136 vessels carrying 2,900 seafarers were evacuated. Although it was not a ceasefire agreement or guarantee that there would not be any more strikes, it was successful and it removed many stranded working people from the Strait.

Possible Solutions

New round of diplomatic talks

A new round of diplomatic talks could prove to be helpful, as the previous ones fell through for many reasons. Through those talks, each party could further delve into and understand the perspectives of the other and could prove to be the solution to the problem. More specifically, these

[65] Gardner, F. (2026, March 26). *Are US-Iran peace talks really taking place?*. BBC News. https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cm29l9r68j8o

[66] Caliber.az. (2026, September 9). *Experts warn: Without Trust, US-Iran diplomacy faces deadlock*. Caliber.Az. https://caliber.az/en/post/experts-warn-without-trust-us-iran-diplomacy-faces-deadlock

[67] UN Security Council Resolution 2817 (2026) - UNDOCS. (n.d.-r). https://docs.un.org/en/s/res/2817(2026)

[68] (ACW), A. C. W. D. (2026, June 9). *The humanitarian impact of the war on Iran*. https://arabcenterdc.org/resource/the-humanitarian-impact-of-the-war-on-iran/

talks could focus on the cessation of attacks, the restoration of transit in the passage, vessel inspections, Iranian clearance requirements, military deployments, and possibly a resolution that mandates what will happen to the Strait from now on. Such talks could be facilitated through the UN, and it would happen under Article 33 of the UN Charter, which calls for the peaceful resolution of disputes between countries. A team of diplomats could monitor the situation between the leaders of the countries involved. If a party refuses to engage in these conversations, the UN would send mediators between the countries involved to try and solve the issue remotely.

Restoration of the Traffic Separation Scheme (TSS)

The UN could organise a meeting where the Ministers of Foreign Affairs of Iran and Oman would meet, and where they would be able to talk through the TSS again and try to find a way to rework this measure. If that were to happen, the UN could appoint qualified personnel who would ensure peaceful negotiations between the two, as well as very strict security measures, so as to avoid escalation. This solution is based on Article 33 of the UN Charter, as it calls for peaceful negotiations in order to rework the Scheme. If one of the countries involved were to reject this initiative, the UN would send over diplomats who would talk with the corresponding people, and they would emphasize the importance of these talks, as well as the immediate need for a solution for the way that the Strait would work.

The creation of an internationally monitored maritime deconfliction mechanism

The creation of such a mechanism would happen under the auspices of the UN, and it would appoint certain personnel who would not be involved in the military to monitor the Strait. This solution would essentially create a mechanism through which the area would be watched over and that it could reduce the risk of escalation at sea. The people that would ensure the peacekeeping would be specialized personnel, trained by the UN so that they could control any issues and resolve unpleasant situations. The UN could periodically send authorised personnel that would ensure compliance and that the measures were kept, and that there was actually peace in the area. Essentially, escalation would be prevented by the position of the personnel, meaning that they would be strategically placed in areas that in the past had heightened tensions, and therefore they would be able to control the issue immediately.

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